same old Congress double-talkers on 1984. Their disillusionment burst forth in howls of rage.

The interview was a smash hit in TRPs. It also got more than 2 million views on YouTube. But even more tellingly, it sparked off a slew of videos and tweets that lampooned and ridiculed Rahul. For example: ‘Arnab is looking to London, Rahul is talking to Tokyo’; ‘Arnab qs: What if aliens invade India? Rahul ans: I want to say our government brought in RTI’; ‘Arnab qs: What is the capital of China? Rahul ans: Women’s Empowerment!’; ‘Charlie Chaplin died again yesterday laughing in his grave after watching the interview’; ‘After Comedy Nights with Kapil, we must now have Comedy Nights with Rahul!’; ‘Rahul walks into a bar and lowers it!’ It just went on and on. Amul even had a hoarding: ‘Najawab Rahul’.

Till that interview, Rahul Gandhi (or RaGa, as he is referred to in cyberspace) was targeted by his critics as ‘pappu’, suggesting he was just a novice, a kid in comparison to Modi (or NaMo). The Congress claimed the criticism was unjustified and Rahul was just waiting for the right moment to prove himself as a leader of substance. But now, the interview only confirmed the caricature of him as a babe in the political woods. In most urban, English-speaking middle-class homes in particular, RaGa was now really a pappu, unfit to be prime minister of the country, woefully short of the muscularity and dynamism that the voter seemed to crave.

The next morning, I telephoned Rahul’s key aide Kanishka Singh to remind him of my long-pending interview request. ‘Now that you’ve done one, I’m sure you can do more,’ I pleaded. ‘Of course, we will do more and am sure you’ll get one. By the way, how do you think the interview went?’ he asked. I didn’t really know what to say. If I was brutally honest, I’d probably lose a chance to interview Rahul. If I lied, I wouldn’t be professional. So, I played the diplomat, saying, ‘It was good to see Rahul take all questions, but maybe he could have prepared himself better.’ Kanishka assured me he would.

Sadly, he didn’t need to. The adverse fallout of the interview meant that Rahul went back into his shell, as did his entire team. He did a couple more